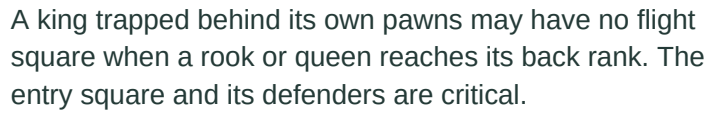


Back-rank mates

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES



Inspect the king's pawn shelter, then find how a heavy piece can enter the last rank or remove its defender.

The defending king is on g1. Geometrically undefended: rook on b7 and knight on g5. Check for tactical protection.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

22...Ne2+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. Recorded reply: **23.Kh1.**

23...Nxf2+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. The move also takes the pawn on f2. Recorded reply: **24.Rxf2**.

24...Rc1+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. Recorded reply: **25.Rf1.**

25...Rxf1# Mate: rook on f1 gives check; White has no legal reply.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on h1. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Rook on f1. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

A flight square, an interposition, or a countercheck may refute an apparent mate. Check all three before sacrificing material.